leaders of Soviet science was the sorry state of Soviet theoretical physics, so, with the blessing of the Communist party and the government, the most brilliant and promising young theorists in the U.S.S.R. were brought to Leningrad (Saint Petersburg) for a few years of graduate study, and then, after completing the equivalent of a Ph.D., were sent to Western Europe for one or two years of postdoctoral study.

Why postdoctoral study? Because by the 1920s physics had become so complex that Ph.D.-level training was not sufficient for its mastery. To promote additional training worldwide, a system of postdoctoral fellowships had been set up, funded largely by the Rockefeller Foundation (profits from capitalists' oil ventures). Anyone, even ardent Russian Marxists, could compete for these fellowships. The winners were called "postdoctoral fellows" or simply "postdocs."

Why *Western Europe* for postdoctoral study? Because in the 1920s Western Europe was the mecca of theoretical physics; it was the home of almost every outstanding theoretical physicist in the world. Soviet leaders, in their desperation to transfuse theoretical physics from Western Europe to the U.S.S.R., had no choice but to send their young theorists there for training, despite the dangers of ideological contamination.

Of all the young Soviet theorists who traveled the route to Leningrad, then to Western Europe, and then back to the U.S.S.R., Lev Davidovich Landau would have by far the greatest influence on physics. Born in 1908 into a well-to-do Jewish family (his father was a petroleum engineer in Baku on the Caspian Sea), he entered Leningrad University at age sixteen and finished his undergraduate studies by age nineteen. After just two years of graduate study at the Leningrad Physicotechnical Institute, he completed the equivalent of a Ph.D. and went off to Western Europe, where he spent eighteen months of 1929–30 making the rounds of the great theoretical physics centers in Switzerland, Germany, Denmark, England, Belgium, and Holland.